

NATURAL Born Actors



No flash stardom. No craving for meteor showers. No money grubbing. These are performers who take their work seriously, choosing films for love, not lucre. In a world of cleavage and contacts, gleaming pecs and smooth six packs, they stand out for more than just their celestial bodies.

By Kaverie Bamzai

Thinking Woman's Crumpet, *Farhan Akhtar, 35*

He can sing, dance and act. So it's almost with a relief that one notices a scar under his right eye, the result of a deep wound sustained at the age of three when careening into a glass table. And that he has an almost permanent cold, requiring a baby assistant who is all of 20, to always place a packet of tissues within easy reach. Farhan Akhtar's friend, director Reema Kagti, knew something the rest of the world is discovering only now. That he is actually a superhero in disguise. Which is why she offered him the role of Aspi, the superbaby, in her debut film *Honeymoon Travels Ltd.* in 2007. Farhan did not do his former assistant's movie, but he did do another friend Anand Surapur's *The Fakir of Venice*. That film is yet to be released but it led to Abhishek Kapoor casting him in *Rock On!!* And his sister Zoya putting him in *Luck By Chance*, a movie she took eight years to make.

And now here he is, the son of child actor-turned-writer Honey Irani and writer Javed Akhtar, at 35, with a track record classic Bollywood would be proud of. As producer of Excel Productions, he and Manekji Cooper classmate Ritesh Sidhwani have set up a company that picks and chooses sensible films that do well at the box-office. He's directed three films, been a reality show judge as well as a chat show host. And now as an actor, he has shown he can be subtle and showy. Perhaps it was to be expected. As children,

Farhan and older-by-a-year Zoya were exposed to various worlds. Their mother studied direction at FTIL, their father was a writer. They separated but the children went everywhere—sometimes an art exhibition, at other times a star child's birthday (Abhishek Bachchan, Hrithik Roshan, Aditya and Uday Chopra are buddies) and yet other times to film sets. So how does he do it all? "As a director, moods flare, egos are bruised. You're focused on other people performing well. Acting is very much about you. You have to create a wall around yourself. You are constantly being sent off to your van, there's a problem with the crane or with the light." He says he doesn't have the level of skill right now to direct and act. But what works for him as a filmmaker is simple: the story has to grab you within the first 10 pages. So even as he works on the script for *Don 2* with "two little boys Ameer and Amrisha", gets ready to direct his next movie, *Voice from the Sky*, and starts preparing notes for his role in newcomer Vicky Lalvani's *Kartik Calling Kartik*, Farhan is learning to suffer the limelight that comes with being the thinking woman's crumpet and Everyman's rock star. He's even funny, a quality normally lacking in Bollywood's third person universe. He's become less reticent, less international man of mystery, who speaks only when he absolutely has to. At which point, he smiles, pauses a beat, and then says, "So are we done now?"